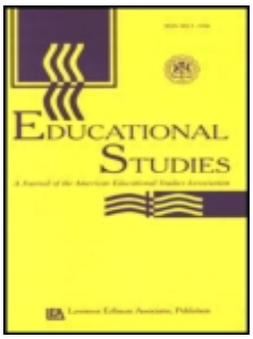

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Queer of Color Agency in Educational Contexts: Analytic Frameworks From a Queer of Color Critique

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Although queer students of color face multiple obstacles to safe and full participation in numerous educational contexts, cultural and scholarly narratives that emphasize their vulnerabilities can lead educational stakeholders to overlook, and thus miss opportunities to capitalize on, the agency that these students possess to negotiate the barriers to their academic success. To counterbalance discourses on youth as *at risk* or *in crisis*, this article explores how a body of critical scholarship known as *a queer of color critique* can serve as a heuristic for educational research on the agentive practices of queer students of color. Situated largely outside of educational studies, a queer of color critique—much like critical race theories, disability studies, and similar discourses on difference—can organize analytic works across subfields of educational scholarship into a more coherent educational research agenda on queer of color difference while also contributing to broader critiques of homophobia, racism, and other threats to social justice in education.

Educational discourses on youth in crisis have raised public awareness of various factors that confound educational access and achievement for diverse student populations in the United States. Unfortunately, they have also reproduced popular cultural narratives on youth victimization that often overlook—and thus miss the opportunity to capitalize on—young people's agency to negotiate the barriers to their academic success (Duncan-Andrade & Morrell, 2008; Harper, 2008; McCready, 2012; Talburt, Rofes, & Rasmussen, 2004). This certainly has been the case for queer students of color.[1] Situated at the intersections of multiple oppressions, the bodies of queer students of color are already marked by crisis-oriented discourses on youth of color, queer youth, immigrant youth, poor youth, and other constituencies to which they belong that are considered *at risk*. Additionally, growing public concern in recent years around homophobic bullying has intensified the spotlight on the victimization of queer students of color (as well as those [mis]perceived as such) in K–12 schools and postsecondary institutions. Media coverage of incidents like the fatal shooting of Lawrence King inside a California junior high school (Setoodah, 2008), the homophobic violence toward and harassment of gay and gender nonconforming students at Morehouse College (Knight, 2010; Lee, 2003), and the suicides of bullied young students like Jaheem Herrera (Simon, 2009) and Carl Walker-Hoover (James, 2009) locate queerly marked students of color within contemporary narratives on queer youth victimization. Despite

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the aspirational claim that "It Gets Better" for queer youth (Puar, 2010), coverage of incidents like those listed reinforces a disheartening link in the American imaginary between queer students of color and tragic endings.

At issue here is not whether these acts of violence deserve public outrage, for they do without question. However, as Talburt et al. have argued (2004), there is an overdetermined logic to cultural narratives on queer youth victimization that downplays, or even misses, the transformative possibilities of queer youth agency. On the margins of more prominent discourses on victimhood, "Queer youth agency, whether linked to sexual desire or activity, or to projects of crafting the self and relations to others, is relegated to the domain of the unthinkable" (Talburt et al., 2004, p. 7). This unthinkability, as Blackburn notes (2005), is already evident in educational scholarship that relies upon and reproduces queer victimization tropes. It is also exacerbated by heteronormative blinders in the scholarship on students of color and racial blinders in the scholarship on queer students that have minimized the attention to queer students of color in educational research (McCready, 2010; Patton, 2011), thus excluding them from analyses of youth of color and queer youth agency. For the field of educational studies, these circumstances call not only for more research on queer students of color, but also for new analytical lenses that can bring agency more consistently to the fore. It is crucial that educational researchers find ways to balance a concern for the social and academic dilemmas facing queer students of color with an investigation of the agentive practices that enable these youth, ideally with ally and institutional supports, to successfully negotiate the obstacles to their academic and personal successes.[2]

To that end, this article reviews a body of critical scholarship, situated outside of educational studies, that can serve as a heuristic for educational research on the agentive practices of queer students of color. Just as Kumashiro (2001) looked to scholarship beyond educational studies to frame his trailblazing edited collection of texts by and about queer students of color, this article draws upon the rich body of work that has emerged since Kumashiro's anthology—a body of work dubbed a queer of color (QOC) critique (Ferguson, 2004)—to shape an analytic framework for examinations of QOC agency. In what follows, this article offers an overview of a QOC critique, describes its implications for educational research, and highlights specific concerns that deserve close attention in future research. This article also considers how a QOC critique—much like critical race theories (Lynn & Dixson, 2013), disability studies (Gabel, 2005), and other discourses on difference originating outside of educational studies—can organize analytic works across subfields of educational scholarship into a more coherent educational research agenda on QOC difference. The scholarly framework developed in this article will be of interest to those who want to improve the academic experiences of queers of color, as well as to those who are committed more broadly to supporting research that challenges homophobia, racism, and other threats to equity and justice in American education.

A QUEER OF COLOR CRITIQUE

Gaining its title from Ferguson's analysis of the historical formation of Black queer subjectivities (2004), a queer of color critique indexes an interdisciplinary corpus of scholarship on the dialectics between hegemony and resistance that shape the lives of queer people of color. Like Indigenous studies (L. T. Smith, 1999), Black feminism (B. Smith, 1983), and other bodies of scholarship that attempt to disrupt the subjugation of oppressed peoples, a QOC critique insistently seeks to

unveil the social and historical forces that have produced QOC marginality, as doing so provides a backdrop for exploring strategies of resistance. Importantly, those resistances are rooted in the specificities of QOC lived experiences. As Allen poignantly notes, critical work by Black queer and QOC critics challenges positivist science as well as postmodern "theoretism" that claim that "knowledge is not situated, but lodged somewhere far from where Black queers live, and whose pretensions to universalism only serve to further marginalize us" (Allen, 2009, p. 323). Contrary to dominant forms of knowledge production that cast truth claims about queers of color from afar, a QOC critique engages ways of knowing and being from within queer communities of color. This will become evident as scholarly works from the field are referenced throughout this article.

Although a QOC critique emerges from the lived experiences of queer communities of color, it is also informed by two prominent theoretical legacies. First, a QOC critique engages queer studies' concern for the disruptive possibilities of transgressive gender and sexual formations amidst patriarchal and heteronormative regimes (Eng, Halberstam, & Muñoz, 2005; Jagose, 1996; Sedgwick, 1993; Warner, 1993). By exposing and contesting the historically contingent logics that construct queer deviancy, queer studies has informed efforts within a QOC critique to explore "the meanings, expressions, and possibilities of sex and sexuality generated among sexually nondominant and historically excluded social groups, often by scholars who come from sexualized nondominant social worlds" (Reddy, 2011, p. 167). Although influential literature on lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender people of color predates a QOC critique (Beam, 1986; Lorde, 1984; Ratti, 1993), the engagement with the possibilities (and, as discussed later, the dilemmas) of queerness as an identitarian, political, and intellectual discourse for nonheteronormative people of color distinguishes a QOC critique from earlier works. References to queer Asian American studies (Eng & Hom, 1998), Puerto Rican queer studies (L. M. La Fountain-Stokes, 2009), queer South Asian diasporic texts (Gopinath, 2005), queer Dominican criticism (Decena, 2011), and Black queer studies (Johnson & Henderson, 2005) attest to the racialized engagement with queerness that characterizes and distinguishes a QOC critique.

Along with queer studies, US women-of-color feminism from the 1970s and 1980s provides another theoretical anchor for a QOC critique. Texts by women of color feminists like Moraga and Anzaldúa (Anzalduúa, 1987; Moraga, 1983; Moraga & Anzalduúa, 1983), B. Smith (1983), and Lorde (1984) chart a politics of difference that acknowledges the multiple and intersecting subjectivities of women of color, and that explores shifting strategies of resistance that respond to multiple and intersecting systems of oppression. For contributors to a QOC critique, these intersectional analyses of identities and oppressions make US women-of-color feminism a widely acknowledged generative source for antihegemonic intellectual production (Cohen, 2005; Decena, 2011; Eng & Hom, 1998; Ferguson, 2004; Hames-Garcia, 2011; Hames-Garcia & Martínez, 2011; Hong & Ferguson, 2011; L. M. La Fountain-Stokes, 2009; Manalansan, 2003; Miao, 1998; Muñoz, 1999; Rodriguez, 2003; Somerville, 2000). Several authors even cast women-of-color feminism as an intellectual corrective to queer theory's failure to consistently engage intersectional analyses (Eng & Hom, 1998; Hames-Garcia & Martínez, 2011; Hong & Ferguson, 2011). The prevalence of references to Moraga, Anzaldúa, and others attests to women of color feminism's role as a crucial foundation for a QOC critique.

Together, the engagements with queer studies and women of color feminism have forged an analytic lens within a QOC critique that presents two key affordances: It names and contextualizes the marginalization of QOC difference; and it differentiates strategies of resistance to account for the shifting exigencies of the lives of queers of color. Although other scholarly fields have

demonstrated a dual concern for the sociohistorical context of marginalization and the resistive strategies that result, a QOC critique has done so specifically with QOC lived experiences as primary sources for knowledge production. This is what distinguishes a QOC critique from other fields as a unique and compelling heuristic for investigating QOC encounters with and resistance against multiple systems of power in any number of contexts, including education.[3] Furthermore, it is through its dual attention to how queers of color are constituted within, and resistant against, intersecting arrangements of power that a QOC critique leads us to analyses of agency. Set against portraits of the material and ideological forces responsible for marginalizing queers of color, scholarly works in this field of study trace the identity constructions, cultural practices, knowledge productions, political contestations, and communal formations employed by queers of color to create space for their ways of being, and to chart pathways toward their desired social futures. Within a QOC critique, agency is seen through the determination of QOC subjects to strategically imagine subjectivities and forge realities that defy the logics and constraints of QOC marginalizations.

Although this understanding of agency could lead scholarly analyses in any number of directions, repeated engagements with anthropology (Allen, 2011; Bailey, 2013; Decena, 2011; Manalansan, 2003) and performance studies (Bailey, 2009, 2013; Johnson, 2003, 2005; Muñoz, 1999; Rivera-Servera, 2011) help to explain the prominent concern within a QOC critique for agentive practices during everyday lived experiences. This attention to the quotidian realities of QOC lives spotlights the agency of individual and collective actors as they attempt to negotiate and perform identity, belonging, and resistance on self-determined terms. One example of this portrayal of agency is Manalansan's (2003) ethnography of queer Filipino men in New York City, in which he asserts the significance of "interrogating the premises of everyday local existence and the ways Filipino gay men struggle and maneuver in order to survive and even to flourish" (p. xi). After situating his subjects at the intersections of western colonialism in the Philippines, White supremacy in American queer communities, and queer silences within Filipino cultures, Manalansan explores a range of agentive practices including the defiant use of Tagalog in White queer spaces, the resistance against an American queer politics of visibility, and the reliance on friendship and kin networks amidst the HIV/AIDS epidemic. These practices offer examples of queer Filipino men's negotiations of their marginalized social positionalities via agentive assertions of self and community. In similar fashion to Manalansan's work, Bailey's (2013) performance ethnography of Black queer Ballroom culture in Detroit questions "what can be learned from everyday Black LGBT lives in Ballroom culture, particularly those who are largely ignored in dominant academic and sociopolitical discourse" (p. 4). Against the backdrops of Detroit's postindustrial economic woes, stark racial divides, and Black gender and sexual mores—all of which lead "Black LGBT people [to] occupy one of the most marginalized social locations within blackness in Detroit" (p. 4)—Bailey chronicles the creation of supportive kinship networks, performative communal spaces, and interventions against the spread of HIV that enable Detroit's Black queer Ballroom community to survive and thrive on its own resilient terms. By identifying the material and ideological conditions that produce Black queer marginality in Detroit, Bailey provides context for understanding the agentive nature of the Ballroom community's cultural practices.

For Manalansan and Bailey, the social and historical determinants of QOC marginality provide backdrops for examining the agentive practices deployed by queers of color in their everyday lives. This approach to spotlighting QOC agency reemerges throughout a QOC critique. For

instance, with racial politics, masculinity regimes, and socioeconomic uncertainty as context, Decenas (2011) explores how queer Dominican men use gender performance, kinship networks, and degrees of queer invisibility to navigate their lives in New York City. Allen (2011) sets the economic precariousness and heteronormative social policies of contemporary Cuba as backdrops for examining intimate friendships, sex work, and grassroots HIV prevention efforts as agentive social practices for Black queer Cubans. For Johnson (2008), the social, cultural, economic, and political landscapes of the American South provide terrain for tracing the agentive everyday practices of Black queer men, while HIV/AIDS activism, the American judicial system, and cyberspace function as backdrops for Rodriguez's (2003) examinations of queer Latino and Latina agency. Across these works, agency emerges as the ability of QOC subjects in their everyday lives to negotiate the myriad challenges to their self-determination and survival.

The focus on everyday agentive practices has coincided well with the culturally bounded scope that typifies many of the scholarly works in a QOC critique. Though scholars in the field routinely cite and build upon each other's works, their respective analyses usually attend to the lived experiences of a specific QOC group—Filipino queer men in New York City, for example. This specialized lens is extremely valuable for a QOC critique, as it ensures that the particular experiences of QOC constituencies are not sacrificed in service of a grand narrative of QOC progress. It does leave room, however, for further considerations of how agency (and other topics) can be understood across the experiences of multiple groups of queers of color. Based on a review of extant literature in the field, this article identifies three recurrent themes from a QOC critique that can capture the self-making and space-navigating strategies of multiple groups of queers of color. Bringing these recurrent themes to bear on educational scholarship can enable an expanded research agenda that explores and learns from the agentive practices of queers of color in educational spaces.[4]

QUEER OF COLOR AGENCY AND EDUCATIONAL SCHOLARSHIP

Although the scholarly works that comprise a QOC critique offer a unique set of insights into the lives and agency of queers of color, they have yet to develop a sustained analysis of educational contexts, perhaps due to their location primarily outside of educational studies.[5] Therefore, as this article reviews key themes from a QOC critique, connections are made to extant educational literature to demonstrate the relevance of these themes for educational scholarship, and recommendations are offered for growing these themes into a fuller research agenda. In what follows, three recurrent themes are presented that pose salient implications for educational research on QOC agency: the politics of knowledge production; the lived experiences of intersectionality; and the politics of queer visibility.

The Politics of Knowledge Production

Since the late 1990s, a QOC critique has emerged within and in spite of a contentious politics of knowledge production that traditionally has underwritten QOC marginality. To secure discursive space for new modes of scholarship on queers of color, contributors to a QOC critique have

engaged a number of strategies to resist exclusionary scholarly regimes. For instance, scholars in the field have openly critiqued the heteronormative racial narratives that produce QOC invisibility in critical scholarship on race (Cohen, 2005; Eng & Hom, 1998; Gopinath, 2005; McBride, 2005; Walcott, 2005) and the "intellectual Europhilia" (Decena, 2011, p. 212) that centers Whiteness and marginalizes QOC perspectives in queer studies (Allen, 2009; Eng & Hom, 1998; Ferguson, 2004; Hames-Garcia, 2011; Johnson, 2005; Ross, 2005). In contrast to these scholarly discourses, a QOC critique, as noted earlier, has centered the lived experiences of queers of color as sources for knowledge production. By doing so, the field deliberately resists QOC invisibility by recognizing QOC lives as worthy of critical scholarly attention. To date, a QOC critique has been articulated largely by self-identified queer scholars of color whose scholarly productions represent their own intellectual agency—or their determination to engage scholarly discourses on their own terms—as queers of color (Allen, 2009; Bailey, 2009; Decena, 2011; Hames-Garcia, 2011; Johnson, 2005; L. La Fountain-Stokes, 2011; McBride, 2005; Perez, 2005; Rodriguez, 2003). Here, intellectual agency marks QOC scholars' refusal to comply with dominant modes of knowledge production that produce QOC marginality, as well as their efforts to represent their subjectivities and politics through their own scholarly production. Their engagements with the works of other QOC intellectuals, writers, filmmakers, and artists across their texts reinforce an intellectual solidarity around the transformative potential of QOC scholarly and cultural productions. Thus, against a contentious backdrop of academic politics, a QOC critique has charted new scholarly terrains for queers of color to assert their intellectual agency over traditionally marginalizing processes of knowledge production.

Although a QOC critique makes space for QOC intellectual agency, it does not fully eliminate the risks of QOC participation in antihegemonic knowledge production. In his analysis of QOC engagements with various modes of artistic and cultural production, Muñoz (1999) asserts that queers of color still must reckon with dominant ideologies on racial and sexual difference as they negotiate their identities and politics vis-à-vis cultural texts and performances. Through a process he calls *disidentification*, Muñoz contends that queers of color learn to concurrently identify with and rework dominant ideologies as they engage in acts of knowledge production. To illustrate, Muñoz conjures the example of a how a young queer woman from the Antilles would need to disidentify with Fanon's valuable anticolonial scholarship, given that author's homophobia and misogyny. For this young queer woman, disidentification would mean that Fanon's "homophobia and misogyny would be interrogated while his anticolonial discourse was engaged as a *still* valuable yet mediated identification" (9). The affordances of Fanon's revolutionary anticolonialism would coexist with the burden of his homophobia and misogyny for the young queer female subject. This mode of disidentification is apparent in a QOC critique. For instance, Gopinath (2005) describes how queer South Asian audiences simultaneously situate themselves within, and read against, heteronormative Bollywood films to imagine queer female subjectivities within those filmic texts, and Fung (1998) considers how Asian queer men both internalize and resist popular orientalist depictions of their sexualities. Other works capture the complicated combination of affiliation and dissonance that confounds QOC scholars' relationships to queer studies, race and ethnic studies, and other academic disciplines (Cohen, 2005; Hames-Garcia, 2011; L. La Fountain-Stokes, 2011; McBride, 2005; Muñoz, 1999; Perez, 2005). Together, these analyses reveal that even as queers of color exert their intellectual agency, they do not emerge unscathed by the hegemonic politics of knowledge production.

Given the socially reproductive function of knowledge production and transmission in schools (Apple, 1982; MacLeod, 2009; McLaren, 1994), it is imperative for educational research to identify strategies for supporting the intellectual agency of queers of color within hegemonic educational contexts. To date, a burgeoning corpus of scholarly literature has started to chronicle the peer conflicts and social exclusions of queers of color in K–12 schools (L. T. McCready, 2010; Ngo, 2003; Quinn, 2007; Vaught, 2004) and postsecondary settings (Harper & Gasman, 2008; Harris, 2003; Patton, 2011; Patton & Simmons, 2008), but analyses of their academic experiences and intellectual agency remain comparatively slim. Of the literature that does exist, standout works by Blackburn (2005), Cruz (2013), and McCready (2013) describe the agentive engagements of queer youth of color with antioppressive curricula in alternative or out-of-school spaces, and Blackburn (2003) also compares the literacy practices of one queer female youth of color across school and out-of-school educational settings. Vaught (2004) poses an insightful critique of her curricular practices as a teacher working with Black queer male high school students in the deep South by noting the limited relevance of positive images of Black queer men like James Baldwin and Langston Hughes, whose life experiences do not speak to the realities of her Black queer male students. In higher educational scholarship, several texts present instructors' pedagogical reflections on their attempts to help students examine intersections of race and sexuality in their own courses (Alexander, 2005; Lewis, 2012; Loutzenheiser, 2001; Ressler, 2001), but few insights have emerged regarding students' academic experiences beyond brief accounts of queer issues being mentioned in select classes (Misa, 2001; Patton, 2011). Overall, these texts point to the significance of QOC academic experiences, but they also leave ample room for further explorations of QOC intellectual agency within a range of educational contexts.

As educational researchers increasingly turn their attention to queers of color, the politics of knowledge production in various educational spaces warrants further investigation. One specific concern that begs closer attention is the relationship between queers of color and curricula. Drawing upon a QOC critique will allow curricular analyses to go beyond the mere inclusion of queers of color, reaching instead for deeper considerations of how various bodies of knowledge have produced QOC invisibility and pathology, and how the inclusion of intellectual and cultural productions by queers of color in curricula may or may not transform the meanings traditionally ascribed to QOC difference. Along with studies of curricula, further examinations of pedagogy and instruction are warranted in educational research on queers of color. This research should expand considerations of how instructors across educational contexts can engage in pedagogical work that acknowledges and complicates students' understandings of QOC difference, and it should intentionally seek out implications for teacher education. Last, analyses of curriculum, pedagogy, and instruction will provide an important backdrop for closer examinations of how queer students of color engage in the transmission and production of knowledge in educational settings. Although such studies should not overlook academic achievement, they must go beyond a concern for test scores and similar indices to investigate how queer students of color negotiate the opportunities and risks entailed in their academic encounters with dominant ideologies. Understanding this process—which one might frame as disidentification—is crucial for supporting the intellectual agency of queer students of color. Together, these recommendations can help move educational research beyond victimization narratives and into the academic lives and intellectual agency of queers of color.

The Lived Experiences of Intersectionality

As noted earlier, theorizations of intersectionality from women of color feminism are foundational to critical scholarship on queers of color. Building upon earlier works from the 1970s and 1980s, Crenshaw (1991) argued for the need to understand the intersectional nature of the racial and gender identities of women of color. As she noted, race and gender, as well as racism and sexism, are not discrete categories of identity and power in the lives of women of color, but rather intersect with each other to produce an experience that is unique to that intersection. This understanding of intersectionality has shaped analyses of the lived experiences of queers of color in a QOC critique. For instance, Decena (2011) and Manalansan (2003) examine the intersections of race, gender expression, class, and immigrant status in the identities of queer Dominican and Filipino men, respectively, in New York City, and Ascensio (2009) describes queer Puerto Rican women's negotiations of race, socioeconomic status, sexuality, gender, and ethnonationality as they grapple with their identities as migrants to New York City or Hartford, CT. Johnson's (2008) rich collection of oral histories of Black queer men in the South explores their negotiations of race, sexuality, gender performance, age, educational status, and other identity markers, and Johnson (2008) and Manalansan (2003), as well as Strongman (2002), examine their respective informants' negotiations of religious identities. Collectively, these works capture myriad, and sometimes conflicted, decisions regarding self-articulations of race, the performance of nonconforming gender expressions, levels of queer disclosure, and the endless array of other negotiations that queers of color must perform as they position themselves in strategic and agentive ways across social contexts. What emerges across this scholarship is not a unified narrative of QOC identification strategies, but rather a nuanced portrait of agentive queers of color whose multiple and intersecting identities necessitate multiple and shifting determinations of how to define their complex selves.

In addition to the identity negotiations noted previously, a number of works in a QOC critique examine sexual identities. These analyses move beyond descriptions of sexual acts to explore how sexuality intersects with other identities to shape QOC informants' sense of self. Examples include analyses of how sexual identities are mediated by gender performance (Allen, 2011; Decena, 2011; Manalansan, 2003) and racial loyalties and preferences (Decena, 2011; Guzmán, 2006; Johnson, 2008; Manalansan, 2003), as well as analyses of how queers of color develop their own sense of sexual agency (Allen, 2011; Decena, 2011; Johnson, 2008; Manalansan, 2003; Rodriguez, 2003). In contrast to homophobic discourses on queer sexualities that marginalize queers of color and deny them access to important knowledge about their sexualities (Allen, 2011; Bailey, 2013; Decena, 2011; Gopinath, 2005), the attention to sexuality in a QOC critique reclaims sexuality as one of the intersecting identities negotiated by agentive QOC subjects.

The importance of recognizing the multiple and intersecting identities of queers of color—and the agentive negotiations of these identities across educational contexts—has already shaped some educational scholarship. For instance, Goode-Cross and Good (2009), Goode-Cross and Tager (2011), and Patton (2011) have found that some Black queer male students prioritize their Blackness over their queerness to strategically align themselves with Black peer groups, and McCready (2010) and Misa (2001) describe queers of color who intentionally downplay their queerness to secure membership in school-based racial communities. Some authors have described how confident assertions of transgender identities (Brockenbrough & Boatwright, 2013)

or nonconforming gender expressions (McCready, 2010; Patton & Simmons, 2008; Quinn, 2007) produce agentive moments as queers of color navigate various educational settings, and Russell (2001) and Battle and Linville (2006) suggest that the demands of negotiating multiple identities may make some queer students of color more resilient than other groups of students. Together, these texts attest to an emergent QOC critique in educational research that recognizes the need to understand how queers of color agentively negotiate multiple and intersecting identities to strategically position themselves in educational contexts. These texts also suggest that what constitutes QOC agency will vary for different QOC subjects in different educational contexts.

As educational researchers expand and deepen their intersectional analyses of queers of color, three dilemmas, in particular, warrant further attention. First, although some works clearly articulate an intersectional analytic framework (Cruz, 2011; McCready, 2010), others recognize the importance of multiple identities without necessarily acknowledging their intersectionality (Goode-Cross & Tager, 2011; Strayhorn, Blakewood, & DeVita, 2010). Drawing upon the intersectional analytic lens of a QOC critique will afford more consistent analyses of how QOC negotiations of intersectional identities enable agentive navigations of educational spaces. Second, although more educational research is needed on all queers of color, the extant literature features more analyses of Black queer males than of any other constituency.[6] Supporting the academic aspirations of queer students of color will require more deliberate efforts to increase the range of constituencies and intersecting identities that get included in QOC educational scholarship. Last, the significance of sexuality within a QOC critique demands a concerted effort to address the deafening silence in educational research on the sexual identities of queers of color. This silence is not surprising, because homophobic cultural discourses have cast queer sex as a threat to children (Rofes, 2005), thus pressuring schools to homophobically exclude queer sex from antihomophobic educational initiatives. However, given the centrality of sexuality to queer youth identity development and the heightened sexual risks that some queer youth of color face in the absence of accessible and accurate information on queer sex (Fields et al., 2006), a QOC critique in educational research must begin to consider how schools can support the sexual identity formation and agentive sexual decision-making of queer students of color.

The Politics of Queer Visibility

In "Beyond the closet as raceless paradigm," Marlon Ross (2005) asserts that with the reliance on Whiteness in seminal queer theory texts, the casting of coming out as a liberatory act reflects a White middle-class epistemological bias that does not necessarily resonate for queer subjects marked by racial difference. This ambivalence toward coming out or the politics of queer visibility—a central strategy in queer rights struggles in the United States (Ross, 2005)—surfaces in other QOC scholarly texts. For instance, Manalansan describes how *pakiramdaman,* a Filipino notion of identities being detectable without the need for public declarations, led queer Filipino men in New York City to downplay and even dismiss the importance of coming out, with one informant stating, "The Americans are different, darling. Coming out is their drama" (Manalansan, 2003, p. 27). Gopinath describes representations of South Asian queer female subjectivity based in the private, homosocial space of the home that challenge "dominant Euro-American narratives of an 'out,' visible 'lesbian' identity" (Gopinath, 2005, p. 26). Decena (2011) describes how queerness operated for queer Dominican men in New York City as a "tacit subject," and he

explains how keeping queerness tacit was vital for sustaining kinship support networks in economically marginalized migrant communities. Ramirez (2011) notes how a politics of outness failed to resonate with some members of Latino queer communities in San Francisco, particularly queer male migrants, and Johnson (2008) explores how some Black queer men in the South shy away from coming out to maintain family and community membership, yet still experience contented lives as queer subjects. By bringing race, class, and culture to bear on the politics of queer visibility, a QOC critique casts insightful doubts on the liberatory effects of coming out for non-White queer subjects. In the process, performing degrees of queer *invisibility*—where queerness may be completely hidden or, if visible, is not openly acknowledged—emerges as an agentive practice for queers of color who prioritize connectedness with families and racial communities over coming out.

Despite this ambivalence toward coming out, a QOC critique never wholly dismisses a politics of queer visibility. This is surely due, in part, to the field's reliance on queer outness to establish its very presence, but it also reflects the embrace of queer visibility by some queers of color in their daily lives. Several works, for instance, recount collective QOC participation in political coalitions that have mobilized queer outness to advocate for various social justice concerns (Cohen, 2005; Miao, 1998; Yoshikawa, 1998). Other works describe the factors that lead individual QOC subjects to come out even if many of their peers have shied away from queer visibility (Decena, 2011; Johnson, 2008; Manalansan, 2003). Degrees of queer visibility have also enabled the formation of pride events, clubs and other social spaces, and social services outreach efforts catered toward queers of color (Decena, 2011; Ramirez, 2011), regardless of participants' own degrees of outness. Overall, a QOC critique recognizes the gains that have been secured through QOC visibility, but it also acknowledges that those gains have not been equally enjoyed by all queers of color.

The mixed reception toward the politics of queer visibility, described previously, runs counter to anti-homophobic educational scholarship and advocacy efforts that have traditionally cast coming out as an agentive and emancipatory act (Biegel, 2010; Jackson, 2007). Thus, suggesting a tempered desire for queer outness in schools may seem counterintuitive to some. As described, what makes a QOC critique so useful here is that it situates the ambivalence toward coming out in the racially and culturally mediated lived experiences of queers of color. Any scholarly attempts to address the exigencies of the lives of queers of color cannot ignore the tensions surrounding the politics of outness. Fortunately, current educational scholarship has already provided a foundation for exploring these tensions. To date, several works have included depictions of queer students of color who have performed queer visibility as a strategy for agentively navigating high schools (McCready, 2010), charter schools (Quinn, 2007), and predominantly White college campuses (Strayhorn et al., 2010). By contrast, other works have described how Black queer male high school students (McCready, 2001; Vaught, 2004), Black queer college students at historically Black colleges and universities (Goode-Cross & Tager, 2011; Harper & Gasman, 2008; Patton, 2011; Patton & Simmons, 2008), and migrant queer youth of color in an alternative educational program (Cruz, 2008), either remain in the closet or disclose their queerness discreetly, thus maintaining degrees of queer invisibility. These examples indicate conflicted attitudes toward coming out in QOC educational experiences that deserve further exploration by educational researchers.

All of the literature cited underscores the need for further educational research on QOC negotiations of the politics of queer outness. Because extant scholarship points to the mediating effects of educational contexts, future research should continue to intentionally investigate how varied

settings (charter vs. comprehensive high schools, northern vs. southern geographic locations, predominantly Black vs. predominantly White colleges, etc.), shape the affordances and constraints of queer visibility and invisibility as agentive strategies for navigating educational spaces. Close attention should also be devoted to the implications of the politics of queer visibility for individual QOC subjects, as well as for the collective status of queers of color within various educational contexts. For instance, what circumstances lead queer students of color to embrace or resist queer visibility? How do they understand the affordances and constraints of the strategies they engage? How do the tensions between queer visibility and invisibility affect activism by and for queers of color in various educational spaces? How should educational institutions approach curriculum efforts, support services, awareness-raising programming, and other initiatives that may increase the visibility of queers of color if some prefer degrees of queer invisibility? Rather than producing a single grand narrative of QOC liberation in schools, the answers to these questions will force a scholarly reckoning with a more diverse and authentic array of possibilities for QOC agency in education.

EXPANDING A QOC CRITIQUE IN EDUCATIONAL RESEARCH

Educational researchers have repeatedly looked to intellectual discourses situated outside of existing educational scholarship to enhance the understanding of the politics of difference in educational contexts. Just as critical race theories (Lynn & Dixson, 2013) and disability studies (Gabel, 2005) have proven productive heuristics for critical examinations of identity, power, and difference in schools, a QOC critique offers insights and raises questions that can deepen and expand intellectual production on queers of color in education. As with the bodies of scholarship mentioned previously, it would be a mistake to dismiss a QOC critique as a niche academic project with limited relevance to broader scholarly audiences. The processes that produce QOC marginality in schools—the processes that a QOC critique would seek to disrupt—also shape much larger sets of educational politics that affect the lives of a vast array of stakeholders. For instance, as Harper and Gasman (2008) note, homophobia on historically Black college and university campuses stems from a tradition of institutional conservatism that curtails the sexual freedoms and self-expressions of all students at these institutions, and that positions them as subordinates to faculty and administrators. Similarly, Quinn (2007) describes a policy at a charter school that not only prevented queer teachers of color from coming out, but also reflected a larger encroachment on teachers' freedoms in nonunionized charter schools. These examples illustrate how scholarship on queers of color can address the specificities of QOC experiences while also illuminating hegemonic processes that impose upon a wide array of educational stakeholders. Consequently, a QOC critique must be understood as an analytic lens with far-reaching affordances for educational scholars, including those who may not be specifically interested in queers of color but share a concern for social justice in education.

This article introduces the possibilities of a QOC critique in education by focusing specifically on QOC agency. As noted earlier, the focus on the agentive practices of queer students of color provides an important counterbalance to discourses that reify narratives of youth victimization. Because this article's attention was confined to the study of QOC students' agency, it would be premature to posit a fixed set of tenets or principles to guide the more expansive possibilities of a QOC critique in education. However, the review of literature presented in this article does lead to

three framing questions that seem crucial for ongoing and future efforts to explore the agentive practices of queer students of color.

1. How do processes of knowledge production and transmission in educational contexts construct QOC difference, and what curricular and pedagogical strategies will enhance QOC students' intellectual agency as they negotiate the opportunities and risks of participating in processes of knowledge production and transmission?
2. How do the cultural and institutional politics of difference act upon the multiple and intersecting identities of queer students of color, and how can these students agentively negotiate these politics and their own identities as they strategically navigate educational spaces?
3. What are the affordances and constraints of the various strategies that queer students of color engage as they negotiate the politics of queer visibility, and how can educational spaces support QOC students' agentive negotiations of those politics?

By posing framing questions here, instead of formal tenets or principles of a QOC critique, this article underscores key themes that warrant further consideration while deliberately inviting other scholars to engage in critical dialogue over the possible answers to these questions.

Despite its limited focus on QOC students' agency, this article can potentially serve as a springboard for a broader QOC critique in education. As more scholars engage in this work, several concerns warrant particular attention. First, it will be important for scholars to consider the specific questions and concerns that a QOC critique can address within various subfields of educational research. Doing so will not only help scholars within various subfields to apply a QOC critique to their work, but it will also enable scholars across those subfields—teacher education, educational policy, curriculum studies, Latino education, and so on—to engage in a collective effort to improve the educational experiences of queers of color. Second, researchers must make deliberate attempts to engage the full diversity of identities that comprise the QOC category, for, as noted earlier, this has yet to occur in the current QOC educational research. Third, a number of questions regarding research methodologies—questions that were not closely examined in this article due to space limitations—will require careful investigation. Although it is not uncommon for educational research to draw upon studies conducted in out-of-school spaces, the methodological implications of moving such research into educational settings—with new questions regarding researcher positionalities, participant safety, participant voices, and so on—warrant strategic consideration. Additionally, methodological diversity will need to be considered, as much of the extant educational research on queers of color relies on qualitative methods.[7] This is not necessarily a call for more quantitative scholarship on queers of color; in fact, Bowleg's (2008) description of the challenges of capturing the intersectionalities of Black lesbians' identities via quantitative methods offers valid reason for concern. Bringing a QOC critique to educational research provides a new opportunity for collective discussions on the affordances and limitations of varied modes of knowledge production for scholarly analyses on queers of color. All of these considerations will be vital to making a QOC critique a relevant heuristic for educational research.

Finally, scholars who examine the educational experiences of queers of color must consider how to contend with the resistance that this work may engender. This resistance may come from multiple sources: school or college and university administrators who may oppose making their institutions accessible as sites for research on queers of color; academic journals and

grant-awarding foundations that may dismiss the salience of this research; colleagues in various subfields of educational research who may challenge the relevance of QOC experiences to current dominant conversations; and perhaps some queers of color themselves who may be wary of scholarly efforts that might increase their visibility. The minimal attention to queers of color across a number of scholarly discourses in educational literature speaks to a politics of knowledge production which, intentionally or not, has reproduced QOC invisibility. Naming and disrupting that politics will be essential if educational researchers truly want to make room for a QOC critique.

NOTES

1. *Queer* is used in this article to denote same-sex desires and identities, as well as transgender and other gender identities and expressions that are marked in similar fashion as deviant or nonconforming by heteronormative power structures. *Queer of color* is used to denote queer subjects who are marked as non-White and targeted as such under White supremacy; this includes people marked fully or partially as Black, Latino, Asian, or Indigenous/Native American. These uses of *queer* and *queer of color* reflect the deployments of these terms in a queer of color critique, the body of scholarship that is reviewed throughout this article. See Johnson (2005) and Rodriguez (2003) for examples.
2. In this article, *agentive practices* refers to the ways that queer students of color express, perform, disclose, conceal, or prioritize their identities; engage in processes of knowledge production; choose and negotiate peer and social affiliations; and make other decisions that allow them to strategically navigate the institutional and identity politics of various educational spaces. As with the definition of *queer of color*, this article's references to queer of color agency (as described later in the text) reflect the treatment of this concept in a queer of color critique. See Allen (2011), Decenas (2011), Johnson (2005), and Manalansan (2003) for examples.
3. The uniqueness of a QOC critique in this regard becomes especially clear when contrasted to the struggles of White-centered queer studies scholarship and heteronormative scholarly discourses on race to fully account for the lives of queers of color. See this article's section on "The Politics of Knowledge Production" for further discussion and references.
4. Additionally, although not the aim of this article, expanding the research on QOC agency in education may help to further develop understandings of agency across multiple groups of queers of color in a QOC critique more broadly.
5. Exceptions include Johnson's (2008) work, which includes narratives of Black queer male experiences at historically Black colleges, and Alexander's (2005) analysis of his pedagogy as a Black queer professor.
6. A number of examples (Blackburn, 2005; Goode-Cross & Tager, 2011; Harper & Gasman, 2008; Harris, 2003; McCready, 2010; Patton, 2011; Strayhorn, Blakewood, & DeVita, 2008; Vaught, 2004) speak to the focus on Black queer males. Although more scholarship is needed on Black queer males, the extant literature offers more on their experiences than Black queer females (Blackburn, 2003; Patton & Simmons, 2008; Quinn, 2007), queer Latinos (Cruz, 2001; Misa, 2001), queer Asians (Ngo, 2003; Varney, 2001), and trans

students of color (Brockenbrough & Boatwright, 2013). Diaz and Kosciw (2009) include specific attention to Native American queers in their work of queer students of color, but attention to them in the literature overall, as with many other queer of color subgroups, remains scant.

7. Examples of the limited number of quantitative works in the extant literature include Battle and Linville (2006) and Russell (2001), as well as Diaz and Kosciw (2009), who employed mixed methods.

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